

Assignment for March 2, 2026

Data Privacy Breach or Ransom Ware Attack



Equifax Data Breach

Name: Isaac Adebayo

Date: Thursday, March 2, 2026

EQUIFAX



When did breach occur?

The breach occurred in 2017



On March 7 2017, a critical vulnerability in the Apache Struts Software was publicly disclosed. Equifax used Apache Struts to run application on legacy operating system that housed the **ACIS (Automated Consumer Interview System) software**. The next day, the department of homeland security alerted Equifax to the vulnerability. Equifax global threat and vulnerability management (GTVM) emailed this alert to over 400 people on March 9. A meeting was also held on March 16. Equifax however did not fully patch this system. On May 13, 2017 a cyberattack began on Equifax that lasted 76 days

Link to News story

LINKS

USA Official Government Link

<https://oversight.house.gov/wp-content/uploads/2018/12/Equifax-Report.pdf>

<https://www.ftc.gov/node/47878>

<https://www.fbi.gov/news/stories/chinese-hackers-charged-in-equifax-breach-021020#:~:text=Today's%20indictment%20charges%20that%20members,website%20within%20the%20Equifax%20system>

US and FOREIGN MEDIA

<https://www.usnews.com/news/articles/2017-09-08/equifax-breach-could-have-decades-of-impact-on-consumers>

<https://www.theguardian.com/us-news/2017/sep/07/equifax-credit-breach-hack-social-security>

CANADA

<https://www.cbc.ca/news/science/equifax-canada-breach-sin-cybersecurity-what-we-know-1.4297532>

<https://arstechnica.com/information-technology/2017/09/massive-equifax-breach-caused-by-failure-to-patch-two-month-old-bug/>

UK

<https://www.irishlegal.com/articles/uk-fines-equifax-ps11m-for-role-in-major-cyber-security-breach>

<https://ca.finance.yahoo.com/news/equifax-says-15-2-million-uk-records-accessed-175636653--sector.html>



What was the company's response?

On October 3, Richard Smith (Equifax CEO) testified before Congress blaming human error and a failure to communicate the need to apply a patch as underlying reasons for the breach.



Equifax did not see the data exfiltration because the device use to monitor ACIS network traffic had been inactive for 19 months due to an expired security certificate. On July 29, 2017, Equifax updated the expired certificate and immediately noticed suspicious web traffic.



After **updating the security certificate**, Equifax employees identified suspicious traffic from an IP originating in China. The suspicious traffic exiting the ACIS application contained sensitive information files related to consumer credit investigations. Equifax discovered it was under active attack and immediately **launched an incident response effort**.

What was the outcome?



On July 30, Equifax identified several ACIS code vulnerabilities. Equifax noticed additional suspicious traffic from a second IP address owned by a German ISP, but leased to a Chinese provider.



These red flags caused Equifax to shut down the ACIS web portal for emergency maintenance. The cyberattack concluded when **ACIS was taken offline.**

What should have been done to prevent this from occurring



First, a lack of accountability and no clear lines of authority in Equifax's IT management structure existed, leading to an execution gap between IT policy development and operation. This also restricted the company's implementation of other security initiatives in a comprehensive and timely manner. As an example, Equifax had allowed over **300 security certificates to expire, including 79 certificates for monitoring business critical domains.**



Second, Equifax's aggressive growth strategy and accumulation of data resulted in a **complex IT environment**. Equifax ran a number of its most critical IT applications on **custom-built legacy systems**. Both the complexity and antiquated nature of Equifax's IT systems made IT security especially challenging.



Equifax recognized the inherent security risks of operating legacy IT systems because Equifax had begun a legacy infrastructure modernization effort. This effort, however, came too late to prevent the breach.

How safe do you feel with your data

I have a complex view when it comes data. I do secure my data extremely well using file and cloud encryption and download over a secure webpage that uses the most up to date web traffic encryption (TLS 1.3) while accessing such sites by masquerading my IP address. However, new and various types of data is created all the time and technological awareness can only do as much as the storage of personal data

